

Boeing with bankruptcy, but the Air Corps ordered 14 of them anyway. Capable of flying at 300mph (480kph), the Flying Fortress was regarded by the US as the first credible strategic bomber. The RAF, after starting the war with twin-engined long-range bombers, followed on with the four-engined Sterling, Halifax, and Lancaster.

Strategic bombing

To the countries of continental Europe and Japan strategic bombing did not seem such an attractive use of air power. Whether primarily defense-oriented, as in the case of France and the Soviet Union, or bent on aggressive expansionism, as were Germany and Japan, they believed that in any war the crucial battles were going to be fought between armed land forces. Although they did not ignore the potential for direct air attacks

on enemy cities or economic targets, they felt that the essential role of air power must be to increase the chances of victory on the ground.

In the 1930s, Germany was ahead of any other country in its appreciation of the most effective use of air power. The Luftwaffe grasped the importance of seeking the destruction of the enemy's air forces – either in aerial combat or by attacks on airfields and aircraft factories – as a prelude to other air operations. It was trained to give close support to tanks and motorized infantry in mobile warfare, but also prepared for more independent operations, from attacks on tunnels and bridges along key road and rail routes behind the enemy front line, to the bombing of arms factories and fuel depots. Troop transportation and logistical support were other areas to which the Luftwaffe paid close attention, in line with the

German armed forces' general preoccupation with mobility and shock tactics.

Far from ignoring strategic bombing, the Luftwaffe gave careful consideration to issues such as the guidance of bombers on to distant targets at night – a problem that the RAF, for all its obsession with bombing cities, had omitted to take seriously at all. But the Germans failed to develop a successful four-engined heavy bomber, largely because of the inability of German industry to produce adequate engines. For any strategic bombing campaign they would have to rely on twin-engined medium bombers such as the Dornier Do 17 and the Heinkel He 111.

BOMBER FORMATION

A formation of Keystone bombers flies down the Hudson Valley in a display of America's aerial force. At the start of the 1930s these lumbering biplanes represented virtually the entire bomber strength of the Army Air Corps.

